

NIKKICLERKEEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, and this month we're visiting New Zealand, Auckland in fact, and I have Nikki Clerk from Seymour Tours in Auckland. Nikki, welcome to the program. Thank you.

Thank you. It's really nice to be in Australia at the moment, and nice to be a bit warmer. Yes, that's right.

You're over here for the Brisbane Arrival 360 conference, and tell us a bit about yourself first and Seymour Tours. Well, I live in Auckland, and I've got three kids. I spent 20 years being a graphic designer and hiding behind a screen and drawing pretty pictures.

Just seven years ago, I set up a tourism business where we take seniors on holidays around New Zealand predominantly, and the average age of my travelers is about 78. Sometimes we can have a 69-year-old come on a trip, and they might have a stick in their hand and struggle to get on and off the bus, and we might have a 92-year-old who can just skip on and off the bus. In the world that I live in, age is a number, but a lot of the technologies can be quite overwhelming for the market and demographic of the people that we take away, and so what we put together is fully inclusive tours, door-to-door pick-up and drop-off, so that our clients really just don't need to think about anything in terms of their booking at all.

They may have to buy a couple of lunches, but it's all up front and done. So it's a turnkey operation, and they just pay their price, and you take care of absolutely everything. Give us an example of one of the tours you do out of Auckland.

So a trip that I'm just about to run is down based in the central Otago. For my clients, a lot of them live in retirement villages, or they may be living independently, and we've organized their pick-up from their home. We'll transport them to the airport, where they'll connect with their tour manager, that's me on this case, and then we'll fly down to Queenstown.

Once we land in Queenstown, we'll grab a quick lunch, but our first stop on that tour is going into a truffle farm, which a very well-known chef in New Zealand has promoted on his TV show, and this couple will take us out with their legato truffle dog, and we'll do some truffle hunting, and we'll finish that afternoon by having some canapes with truffle in it. The next visit, we stop in at a beautiful garden on a property and visit and get an overview of what this lovely couple are doing just outside of Cromwell, and later that evening they're going to sit us down for a private dining experience, some beautiful Otago wines, and do some wine matching. The other highlights on this six-day tour are a visit to a trophy hunting farm, which is a massive station just out by the Waitaki River, and it's a place where there's all different breeds of deer, there's tar, there's boar, and we go out, we take all our clients out on a four-by-four safari into this beautiful land, and we'll go and see those animals out there.

Later, having dinner at the lodge, by having a piece of venison and seeing how that paddock-to-

table or that farm-to-table experience comes together. We also visit a lady from Otimata Station, and she's a chef, and has written a couple of cookbooks, and when they have the shearing season for their merino lambs, they quite often, she'll be cooking for all of those people, which is a large volume of hard workers doing all the shearing, and so we go and learn first-hand what the farm is doing, what animals they're using, you know, we'll organise some beautiful food with her, or she's going to cook with us. So the tour then continues, just visiting all these different food producers.

Another really exciting visit on the last day of that tour is in Dunedin, where it finishes. There was a couple of senior women that saw a heap of bread coming out of one of the main bakers down there, and it was just getting thrown away, and these people, these two women, were like, must be something we can do with that bread. They've developed a distillery where they make the gin out of the old bread, and so our clients go in there, we make our own gin, we learn about the process, they can bring their own botanicals, have a wonderful afternoon learning how to do that before we fly home.

And then, of course, once we fly back into Auckland, we ensure that they get back home okay at the end of it. So everything's included, they don't need to worry about anything. They just come along for the ride, and we sort of just keep the spirits up and have a lot of fun, you know.

There must be some tremendous interactions between the guests themselves who get to know each other, and probably form really great friendships too. Yep, yep, that's right. So we do small group tours, we take between 8 and 16 people away on our trips, and so these smaller groups really get us, you know, everybody tends to get along really well, there's none of that clickiness that happens on those bigger bus tours.

So it's a really good number to travel with. The smaller group tours and what we do means that we get into the backyards of many people's homes and their properties, and that paints context around the areas that we're travelling into, and so you don't just drive through an area, you drive through but you get a really good first-hand knowledge from a local that's delivering that information. So it's incredibly authentic what they take out the other side of that.

So those smaller groups and the connections just become incredibly tight, and you do, they make long-time friends, and a lot of them will connect again on different tours. And give us a couple of your favourite destinations in New Zealand that maybe are on your tour, you know, run that you could recommend? We've got some amazing scenery and places in our country, in New Zealand, you know, and it could be from Cape Reinga at the very, very top of New Zealand, all the way down to Stewart Island, and I say that we've got a huge diverse amount of scenery. And for us, and for me, it's the people in the areas that, or the DNA that makes up these places that make them particularly special.

And so one of the really special places to me is a property on our High Country Tours, or

Molesworth and Rainbow Station tour I should say, which we run in October, which is springtime. Molesworth Station is the biggest station in New Zealand. It's the size of Stewart Island put in the middle of Canterbury.

And going up there and learning how that land is managed, how they have to give back certain amounts of land to the Crown, how they manage the wilding pines, the ecology of that land, and being up there, and not only experiencing the most incredible scenery, but to be there and learning about how all those operations happen, make it an incredibly beautiful event. A lot of people don't know a lot about the middle of the North Island, but there's some incredible things happening there that people just don't know about, and so that makes it even more special. There's one particular tour that we run every December, and it's called our Kaimanawa Wild Horses, and it's run in the central plateau, which is the very centre of the North Island.

It's where Mount Ruapahu is. The scenery is absolutely stunning, and only once a year the Kaimanawa Wild Trust, they get a concession from the Army, and they take public onto that land, so it's part of the Waiouru Training Centre for our Army. And up there are a number of bands of wild horses, and I grew up with horses, and I spent years trying to find these wild horses, but you never actually see them from the roadside.

You have to be on one of these tours to see them. It completely blew my mind when I had to turn up, and you could see these gorgeous foals and mares and stallions, and when you have them sort of sitting in the foreground of this beautiful Mount Ruapahu, it really is a sensational piece of our country that not a lot of people know, and not even a lot of Kiwis have the privilege to actually visit. So it's an incredibly beautiful place, and that would be one of my other top places.

Nicky Clerk from Seymour Tours, and if there are seniors from Australia who want to connect with you and come over to New Zealand and have you look after them, how can they find you online? The best place to find me is to go straight to my website, which is seymourtours.co.nz, and that's spelt S-E-E-M-O-R-E, seymourtours.co.nz. It's easy to pick up the phone, send me an email, all the phone lines come through to me, so I'd be very welcoming of your phone call, and you'll get a very real, authentic Kiwi experience that you simply cannot buy online. So what we offer is completely bespoke to anything that you'll find online. Great.

Thanks so much for being on the program, Nicky. Thanks for looking after all of our seniors in New Zealand. Yeah, well, my pleasure.

Thank you very much for your time.